

GRE Exam Pattern Guide

Overview

The Graduate Record Examination (GRE) is a standardized test required for admission to many graduate schools. The current GRE General Test is computer-delivered and measures verbal reasoning, quantitative reasoning, and analytical writing skills.

Test Structure

Total Duration: 3 hours 45 minutes

Section Breakdown

1. Analytical Writing Assessment (AWA)

- **Duration:** 60 minutes
- **Tasks:** 2 essays (30 minutes each)
 - **Analyze an Issue:** Present your perspective on a given topic
 - **Analyze an Argument:** Critique the logic of a presented argument
- **Scoring:** 0-6 scale (in half-point increments)

2. Verbal Reasoning

- **Number of Sections:** 2 sections
- **Duration:** 30 minutes per section
- **Questions:** 20 questions per section (40 total)
- **Question Types:**
 - Reading Comprehension (multiple choice)
 - Text Completion (fill in blanks)
 - Sentence Equivalence (select equivalent words)
- **Scoring:** 130-170 scale

3. Quantitative Reasoning

- **Number of Sections:** 2 sections
- **Duration:** 35 minutes per section
- **Questions:** 20 questions per section (40 total)

- **Question Types:**
 - Quantitative Comparison
 - Multiple Choice (one answer)
 - Multiple Choice (multiple answers)
 - Numeric Entry
- **Scoring:** 130-170 scale

4. Experimental Section

- **Duration:** 30-35 minutes
- **Purpose:** Used by ETS for test development (doesn't count toward score)
- **Content:** Either Verbal or Quantitative (indistinguishable from scored sections)

Test Format Features

Computer-Adaptive Testing

- The difficulty of the second Verbal and Quantitative sections adapts based on performance in the first sections
- Better performance on first section leads to harder second section (and potentially higher scores)

Section Navigation

- You can skip questions and return to them within the same section
- You can change answers within a section before moving to the next
- Cannot return to previous sections once submitted

Scoring System

Score Ranges

- **Verbal Reasoning:** 130-170 (1-point increments)
- **Quantitative Reasoning:** 130-170 (1-point increments)
- **Analytical Writing:** 0-6 (0.5-point increments)

Score Reporting

- Scores are available 10-15 days after the test date
- Scores are valid for 5 years
- You can send scores to up to 4 graduate programs for free on test day

Test Frequency and Registration

Test Availability

- Available year-round at test centers
- Can be taken once every 21 days
- Maximum 5 times in a 12-month period

Registration

- Register online at ets.org
- Test fee: \$220 (as of 2024)
- Schedule 2-3 months in advance for preferred dates

Preparation Timeline

Recommended Study Period

- **Minimum:** 6-8 weeks of dedicated preparation
- **Average:** 3-4 months for comprehensive preparation
- **Intensive:** 2-3 hours daily for 2-3 months

Key Preparation Areas

- **Vocabulary:** Focus on high-frequency GRE words
- **Math Review:** Algebra, geometry, data analysis, arithmetic
- **Reading Skills:** Academic-level passages and critical reasoning
- **Writing Practice:** Essay structure and argument analysis

Test Day Tips

What to Bring

- Valid photo ID (passport, driver's license)
- Admission ticket (printed or on mobile)

What's Provided

- Scratch paper and pencils
- On-screen calculator for Quantitative sections
- Break time between sections

Test Center Rules

- No personal items allowed in testing room
- Locker provided for belongings
- Security screening required

Score Interpretation

Percentile Rankings (Approximate)

- **Verbal 160+**: 85th percentile and above
- **Quantitative 160+**: 70th percentile and above
- **Combined 320+**: Competitive for top programs

Program Requirements

- Vary significantly by field and institution
- STEM programs typically emphasize Quantitative scores
- Humanities programs focus more on Verbal and Writing scores